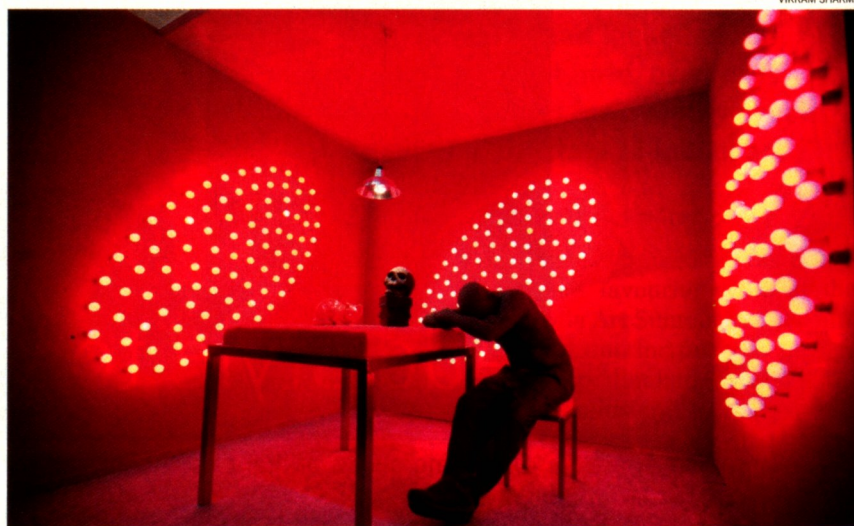




RIDING HIGH: (left) Kallat with his *Collindonthus* and (below) the special installation at the entrance of the Palette Art Gallery

galleries, art funds, auction houses, insurers, framers, valuers and restorers, et al, while exhibitions and biennales bring art and artists under one roof. Under the circumstances, it is to the credit of India Art Summit that it managed both, with a very healthy interaction of the art and the commerce of the industry albeit on a modest scale. Says artist Jitesh Kallat: "It's a great opportunity for Indian art to find a platform like this." He is not new to International Art Fairs and his work "Collindonthus" resembling the fossilised remains of an automobile, was the star attraction at the summit. "The summit has all the right names, from India and abroad, and I'm not just talking of galleries, but individuals, artists and experts, that is what adds credibility to any venture," he adds.

From discussions on investment in art, and art funds to auction houses and gallery prices, what was evident was that Indian art had grown and moved beyond galleries. "I've never seen so much art in one place, this is a first," says Sheetal Arya, one among the many art students from Mumbai and among the 2,500 that visited the summit on day one, the numbers had tripled by the final day. Which is exactly what Sunil Gautham, managing director of the India Art Summit,



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intended. "We wanted to create a platform for people to interact with artists, buyers, seller and everyone in the art industry." The big topic of conversation at the art forums was the extraordinary growth and estimated value of Indian art. To people outside the art world, it might come as a surprise that there has never been a concentrated effort either by the Government of India or private bodies to showcase Indian art collectively. "It took India 24 years to get the National Gallery of Modern Art going," says Professor Rajeev Lochan, its current director.

Art studies estimate that India has the fourth most buoyant art market in the world. With skyrocketing prices and the increasing affluence of the upper middle classes, art has moved into homes and public spaces. "Art is the new luxury," says Phillip Hoffman of the Fine Art Fund, which invests about \$1-3 million in art every week. Hoffman stressed the fact that "today, art is not just a collectible but an investible". While the global economy has seen slumps, he says that the art market is as yet unaffected. He believes that India, which currently